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Black Mold Guide for Renters

Main Takeaways

- Not all black-colored mold is the same as toxic "black mold," but any kind of mold growth can cause health issues under the right circumstances.
- DIY mold test kits aren't always accurate but can be a helpful first step for discussing a mold problem with your landlord.
- Some mold growths can be prevented, detected, and cleaned without professional help, but getting an expert involved is the best way to make sure your home doesn't have a serious mold problem.

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Black Mold Basics

Household mold is common (especially here in South Louisiana) and typically grows in warm, damp, humid environments. "Toxic" black mold looks greenish-black and grows on materials with high cellulose content that have been exposed to moisture, such as wood, paper, and fabric. While black mold is called toxic because it can produce substances called mycotoxins, it's not necessarily more toxic to humans than any other kind of mold. Not all molds that appear black or greenish-black will be the same as "black

mold" (Stachybotrys chartarum). Some other common household mold types, such as Penicillium or Aspergillus, can look similar but are less likely to be harmful.

Everyone's reaction to mold exposure is different. Some people are more sensitive due to allergies and other conditions, while others will experience no symptoms. It's usually rare to experience mold-related health issues, but large growths of household mold of any type can be dangerous. Some generally-harmless mold species can cause health issues for people with weakened immune systems or chronic conditions like allergies or asthma. Mold exposure has been linked to various symptoms ranging in severity, such as:

- Coughing and wheezing
- Nasal congestion and runny nose
- Itchy, watery eyes
- Skin irritation and rashes
- Headaches
- Fatigue
- Chronic sinus infections
- Difficulty breathing
- Asthma attacks
- Memory problems or mood changes

The most at-risk groups are infants and toddlers, older adults, people with allergies, people with asthma, and people with weakened immune systems.

Household mold is most likely to grow in areas where moisture is present. Knowing where to check for mold is important, as growth can go unnoticed without regular inspection.

- Bathrooms and kitchens: These are obvious areas for mold due to high water usage. Check around sinks, showers, bathtubs, and under appliances like dishwashers and refrigerators. It's also important to pay attention to things like tile grout lines, caulking, and areas with poor ventilation.
- Basements and attics: Basements are less of a concern in Louisiana, but poorly-ventilated attics can be vectors for mold growth. Check walls, floors, and stored items for any signs of mold. Warning signs can include water stains or discoloration.

- Windows and HVAC systems: Condensation around windows and in HVAC systems can be sources of mold growth. Check windowsills, frames, surrounding walls, and HVAC ductworks and vents (if possible).
- Other harder-to-see areas: under carpet padding, behind baseboards and wall cavities, between flooring and subfloors, behind cabinets, etc.

Not all mold growth is visible. Mold spores can grow for a long time before getting large enough to be noticeable to the human eye. Sometimes landlords will also paint over mold growth, knowingly or unknowingly, which can make it more difficult for residents to detect down the line. Some common signs of black mold growth:

- Musty smell: many mold species can cause a noticeable musty/earthy smell even before growth is visible.
- Visible growth: check for dark, circular spots, especially in areas prone to water exposure. Larger growths can appear as irregularly-shaped patches of greenish-black growth, sometimes with a slimy or fuzzy texture.

If you suspect there's mold growth in your living space, professional testing from a mold expert is the gold standard, but this can be expensive or difficult to access. DIY home test kits can be a helpful first step in this process.

DIY Black Mold Test Kits

DIY home mold test kits tend to come in two main types: air quality tests and surface swabs. Both of these can be found online or at local hardware stores. Air quality tests can detect airborne spores before visible growth has started and usually involve a home petri dish set and several days of sample growth time. Surface swabs are used for visible mold patches (or any area of suspected mold growth) and can give a result within minutes, though some need to be shipped to a professional lab for testing.

The first step for any DIY mold test kit is PPE (personal protective equipment). Wear gloves and a mask any time you're handling suspected mold. It's also important to clean and dry the area before testing to make sure you're looking for current growth and not old, inactive spores.

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Air Quality Tests

- Pros:
  - Can detect mold spores that aren't visible
  - Can be a more comprehensive way to detect the presence of any kind of environmental mold
- Cons:
  - May be more difficult for the average person to use (often involves tools like petri dishes that may be intimidating or easy to contaminate)
  - The accuracy can be pretty dubious – if you leave a prepared petri dish out for long enough, it'll grow something, whether or not you have dangerous mold in your house
  - It's also difficult to tell what species the growth is or where it's coming from without further testing, which can be expensive and time-consuming

Surface Swab Tests

- Pros:
  - Can have faster results than air quality tests
  - Can give results for specific areas of suspected growth
  - Can give species-specific results
- Cons:
  - Need to swab each specific area of suspected growth at a time, requiring the use of more tests to sample multiple areas
  - Sometimes need to be shipped to a lab for analysis
  - Often more expensive than general air quality tests

Test links:

- Mold Armor Do It Yourself Mold Test Kit, DIY At Home Mold Kit FG500 - The Home Depot
  - Pros: This kit is $9.87, can be found at Home Depot, includes 3 types of tests, and has an option to mail to a lab to find the specific mold type (for an extra fee).
  - Cons: It isn't black mold specific but can be helpful for general mold testing. It also involves petri dish culture testing which can be more complicated and easier to contaminate. It could be a helpful starting point but I wouldn't

suggest relying on the results too heavily, as no living space is a sterile environment.

- Amazon.com: Healthful Home 5-Minute Mold Test. Aspergillus/Penicillium and Stachybotrys. No Waiting Days for Culture Plates or Labs. Works Even If You Can't See The Mold. Expert Consultation Included. : Industrial & Scientific
    - Pros: This kit uses a swab test to detect specific species of potentially dangerous molds (including black mold). It's easier to use than culture plates and takes 5 minutes to get results.
    - Cons: One kit is $36.97 and it only comes with one swab so you would need multiple if there are several suspected mold growth areas in your living space. It's not as conclusive as professional testing but can still be a good starting point (and likely more reliable for detecting black mold than general air quality cultures).

Interpreting Results

If your DIY test kit comes back positive for mold, don't panic! These tests aren't always accurate and it's easy for people to accidentally contaminate the samples, especially when doing petri dish cultures. Microbial growth is also just a fact of life – it's normal for homes to have some type of mold spores floating around. Just because something grows in a home test kit doesn't mean your living space has dangerous toxic mold or that you're going to experience health issues.

If you have large visible mold growth or potential mold-related symptoms, it's important to contact a mold testing & removal expert, regardless of home test kit results. However, having a positive home test kit can be helpful when bringing mold issues up to your landlord.

Preventing Mold Growth

Most mold prevention involves keeping your home as dry and well-ventilated as possible. Some general tips:

- Get any suspected leaks checked & fixed as soon as possible
- Use a dehumidifier in damp areas
- Use exhaust fans in bathrooms & kitchens

- Open windows if the weather permits (but we're in Louisiana, so considering general humidity and bugs, the weather only permits for approximately two days a year)
- Clean and dry water-damaged areas in 24-48 hours
- Use mold-resistant products in damp areas (for example, mold-resistant paint and primers, or non-porous storage containers)
- Regularly inspect your home for water damage or mold growth

Cleaning Mold Growth

First, it's important to address any moisture problems that are causing the mold growth. Otherwise, the mold will likely return.

Second, it's important to know your limits. It's often possible for people to clean small areas of mold (less than 10 square feet, or a 3 foot x 3 foot area) at home using grocery store cleaning supplies, but it's important to consider your own safety before disturbing the mold growth or using cleaning chemicals. If the mold growth is extensive, in an area that you can't easily access, or causing health issues, it's time to get professional help. If you clean a patch of mold and it returns soon after, you likely have a moisture issue or more extensive hidden mold growth, and it's also time to get professional help.

Third, make sure you're using proper PPE when disturbing any mold growth or using harsh chemicals like bleach! It's recommended to use elbow-length household rubber gloves, goggles to protect your eyes, rubber boots, an N-95 face mask, full-coverage clothing, and proper ventilation (such as an open window or exhaust fan). This will protect you from airborne mold spores as well as chemical fumes.

Steps of the mold cleaning process include:

- **Wear PPE.** Seriously. If you're trying to clean mold and you're wearing the same sort of outfit you'd use to wipe down the kitchen counters after cooking, stop it and read the paragraph above again. Keeping yourself safe is the #1 priority otherwise you're defeating the point of trying to clean the mold.
- Make sure the area is well ventilated. Open windows and doors if possible. This protects you from cleaning product fumes and mold spores, and helps surfaces to fully dry, which can prevent mold from returning.
- For non-porous surfaces (e.g. counters, tile, metal, glass, plastic, ceramic):

    - **Never mix bleach and ammonia.** This causes toxic chloramine gas which can kill you. **Check the ingredients of any products you use** and avoid mixing cleaning products.
    - Spritz your cleaning solution (examples below) on the affected area, then let it sit for 15 minutes to an hour. For tougher mold stains, you may need to scrub them with a brush. After, wipe the area with a clean rag and water then let it dry completely.
        - Undiluted white vinegar alone
        - One cup of bleach mixed with a gallon of water
        - 50/50 mixture of ammonia and water
        - **Do not mix bleach and ammonia. Check the ingredients on any cleaning products you use.**
    - Dispose of all cleaning materials safely. Put all used rags, sponges, gloves, and brushes into a heavy-duty garbage bag and keep it tightly closed until it can be disposed of.
    - Make sure to immediately wash any clothing worn in a separate load from other laundry and use hot water. Don't put the clothing in the same hamper as other laundry, or you're risking mold exposure in the rest of your clothes.
- For softer porous surfaces (e.g. fabric, carpet, wallpaper):
    - Cleaning mold from porous surfaces can be difficult to impossible, as mold can stay hidden in small holes in these surfaces.
    - Unfortunately, your safest bet will be to discard any porous items with mold growth, but for items like carpet or wallpaper it's a good idea to contact a professional since these are more difficult to discard on your own.
    - Make sure to dispose of materials safely – use a heavy-duty garbage bag and keep it tightly closed until it can be disposed of.
- For wood surfaces:
    - In general, mold is more difficult to remove from wood than non-porous surfaces like plastic. You'll want to start with gentler products and detergents before moving to harsher ones to avoid damaging the wood, and you should never mix cleaning solutions.
    - Start with a solution of mild dish detergent and water. Use a sponge or soft-bristled brush to apply the solution, but try not to heavily saturate the area with water, as this will be difficult to dry and can make the mold problem worse. Scrub the area with your sponge/brush gently to protect

any finish or paint on the wood. Then use a clean, damp cloth to wipe away the mold residue. Dispose of the cleaning supplies and laundry properly (see above) to avoid spreading the mold spores to other areas.
    - Allow the surface to fully dry. Even if you suspect there's still mold remaining, wait until the wood is fully dry before trying again. Fans or dehumidifiers can help speed up the process.
    - If necessary, repeat with stronger cleaners. This can include white vinegar or a bleach solution (see above). **Never mix bleach and ammonia.**
    - If necessary, you can try to sand the wood, but this could end up putting more mold spores in the air. Always wait until the wood is dry, use proper PPE, and have a vacuum on hand to get rid of the remaining sawdust.
    - Make sure to dispose of the cleaning materials safely and wash your clothes properly (see above).
    - If you're cleaning hardwood flooring, you can test the damage by pressing a screwdriver into the wood. If the wood feels normal, great! The mold may be mostly surface-level. If the wood feels slightly soft, it may be damaged but salvageable with heavier cleaning. If it feels crumbly or spongey, it may need to be replaced completely and you'll need professional intervention. The same principles apply to a wooden ceiling.
- For drywall surfaces:
    - When checking for mold growth on drywall, remember to look for water stains or damage (these can be red flags for potential mold areas) as well as peeling/bubbling paint (painting over mold or moisture spots can cause the paint to warp). Also check the drywall texture- if it's soft or crumbly, it may need complete replacement and it's time to get professional help.
    - For surface cleaning on drywall, use a cleaning solution (below) to cover the affected area.
        - 2:1:1 ratio of baking soda, white vinegar, and water
        - 3% hydrogen peroxide
    - Let it sit for 10 minutes then scrub the area gently with a soft-bristled brush.
    - After, wipe it clean with a damp cloth and allow it to dry completely. Fans or dehumidifiers can help speed up the process.

    - If that doesn't get rid of the mold, deeper cleaning (often involving cutting out the affected drywall) is needed and it's time to contact a professional.
    - Make sure to dispose of cleaning supplies & laundry properly (see above).
- If you plan to paint any of these surfaces after cleaning, make sure they're fully cleaned and dried first.
- If you're unsure how to clean mold off of an item, it's best to contact a professional first.

There's a reason most of these cleaning steps involve the recommendation to contact a professional. If you, your housemate, or your landlord try to clean extensive mold growth without expert help, it could do more harm than good.

Finding a Mold Removal Professional

If you're renting, you might need your landlord's buy-in to call a mold remediation expert. However, if your home needs specialist mold cleaning to be livable and your landlord doesn't hire professionals themselves, you may be able to pay for testing/cleaning and deduct the cost from your rent (always check your local & state laws around renter's rights first or talk to a lawyer if possible). Talk to your landlord – it may help to have positive mold DIY test results and pictures as examples. Keep documentation of all related conversations, tests, and repairs, as well as dated pictures of the affected areas. If you're having mold-related health issues, keep all relevant medical records as well.

Some sources for mold testing & remediation professionals include:

- Professional Directory | Indoor Air Quality Association
- Consultants Directory | AIHA
- NORMI Pro Professional, Certified Mold Inspector and Mold Removal Directory
- National Association of Mold Remediators and Inspectors (NAMRI) | Membership for Mold Professionals

Some questions to ask before hiring a mold remediation specialist:

- Do your contractors have mold remediation certification or other specialty abatement licensing?

- Are you insured with mold-specific insurance?
- Are inspection and post-remedial testing included in the cost?
- How will you protect the rest of my home from mold spores spreading due to the work?
- Which steps of the process are included in the contract?
- How much, if any, restoration work will you do after the abatement is completed?
- How long will this project take? Can or should my family stay in the house during that time?

Costs to hire mold testing & remediation professionals will depend on the size of the area affected, the location, and the type of mold. Mold remediation is often charged based on the number of square feet of cleaning needed, so the smaller the affected area, the cheaper the cleaning. Waiting and letting mold grow can drive up the cost significantly on top of being a risk to your health. Small growths can cost $300-500 while larger infestations will be more expensive. Whole-house infestations or infestations that are causing health issues may mean it's time to move.

If you live in a larger complex and you've noticed mold issues in your apartment, talk to your neighbors! It will be easier to approach your landlord as a group. Cleaning mold from multiple sources at once can also help prevent it from returning.

Sources

- Mold | Mold | CDC
- Black mold exposure: Symptoms, treatment, and prevention
- Black Mold Exposure: Symptoms, Risks & Treatment
- Mold Cleanup in Your Home | US EPA
- How To Test for Black Mold - This Old House
- Addressing Mold Issues in Your Home - This Old House
- How to Kill Mold on Wood and When to Call a Professional - This Old House
- A comprehensive guide on how to Remove Mold on Drywall - This Old House
- How Much Does Mold Remediation Cost? (2025 Guide)
- How Much Does Mold Remediation Cost? – Forbes Home